AEC LOGIX

RFP RADAR BONUS | 1-PAGE PLAYBOOK | FOR SMALL AEC FIRMS

5 Requirements That Kill Small-Firm Bids

The five requirements buried in most AEC RFPs that disqualify small firms before the technical review even begins. Built from 50 years of watching good firms lose pursuits they should have won.

THE 5 REQUIREMENTS

AECLOGIX

Start here. Every RFP. Every time.

These five requirements disqualify more small AEC firms than bad design, bad pricing, or bad writing combined. They are administrative, not creative. They are buried in appendices, not called out on page one. Miss one and the proposal dies in review before anyone reads your qualifications.

1 STATE LICENSING AND RECIPROCITY

WHAT IT IS

The principal architect or engineer of record must hold an active license in the project's state. Reciprocity is not automatic.

WHY IT SINKS BIDS

Public-sector RFPs almost always require the responsible professional's license number and state of issuance. Wrong state, missing number, or expired license means administrative rejection before technical review. You never see the bid team.

WHAT TO CHECK

State board registration for every principal who will appear on the qualifications page. NCARB reciprocity or PE comity status for any out-of-state pursuit. California, Florida, New York, and Texas have the strictest rules.

2 INSURANCE ENDORSEMENTS (NOT JUST THE CERTIFICATE)

WHAT IT IS

Specific endorsement forms by form number. CG 20 10, CG 20 37, CG 24 04, and primary/noncontributory language. The ACORD 25 face is not proof.

WHY IT SINKS BIDS

You submit the certificate, they request the endorsements, you have 48 hours to produce them. Your agent takes five to seven days. You miss the deadline. Bid is declared non-responsive and discarded.

WHAT TO CHECK

The insurance exhibit for the exact list of required endorsement forms. Get them from your broker in writing before the submission. If they are not on file, start the request the day the RFP drops.

Miss any of these and the bid is dead.

3 MBE, WBE, AND DBE PARTICIPATION

WHAT IT IS

Minority, Women, or Disadvantaged Business Enterprise participation targets. Usually a percentage of total fee, sometimes a hard dollar floor.

WHY IT SINKS BIDS

Federal, state, and most municipal RFPs require 10 to 25 percent certified participation. You need vetted subconsultants in your database before the RFP drops. Finding a certified firm with AEC expertise inside a two-week submission window is not realistic.

WHAT TO CHECK

Appendix or attachments for the participation goal. Your state's DBE or MBE directory for pre-certified firms. Maintain a standing list of three to five certified subconsultants per discipline you work with.

4 SUBMISSION FORMAT AND DELIVERY

WHAT IT IS

The exact submission specification. Number of hard copies, digital format, upload portal, physical delivery address, time zone, and cutoff time.

WHY IT SINKS BIDS

Received by 2:00 PM local time means received, not postmarked. Three hard copies means three, not two. A PDF over 25MB rejected by the portal is the same as no submission. The dumbest ways to lose a bid are all here.

WHAT TO CHECK

The submission section the moment the RFP drops. Put the cutoff time in your calendar with a 48-hour buffer reminder. Do a dry-run upload to the portal a week before the deadline if one is used.

5 PRIOR EXPERIENCE QUALIFICATIONS

WHAT IT IS

Minimum years of firm experience, minimum number of similar projects, minimum project size thresholds. Often with a five- or seven-year lookback window.

WHY IT SINKS BIDS

'Minimum five similar projects over fifty million dollars in the last seven years' is a hard gate. If your firm does not meet the threshold exactly, teaming or declining are your only options. Pursuing anyway wastes BD time you do not have.

WHAT TO CHECK

The qualifications section first, before any other review. Count your qualifying projects before you decide to pursue. If you are short, team with a firm that meets the gate and negotiate your role up front.

WHAT TO DO WITH THIS

Use it on every RFP. Start today.

Print this page. Tape it above the desk where RFPs land. Before you scope pursuit strategy or bid pricing, run the five checks above in order. If any one fails and cannot be cured inside the submission window, decline the pursuit and save the BD hours.

1. **Run your last three losing bids through the list.**
   You will find at least one of these five requirements was missed, rushed, or unchecked. That tells you where your process is leaking.
2. **Build standing lists.**
   Three to five MBE/WBE subconsultants per discipline. Your agent's contact on speed dial for endorsement requests. State license renewal dates on a shared calendar.
3. **Use RFP Radar on every RFP that hits your inbox.**
   The tool you already have access to. Paste the RFP. Get the full priority-ranked checklist including the five above, plus everything else buried in the document.